

Work For in India ranking this year.

Step by step, the bank has moved towards its goal. On the path to digital banking and 'Bank to BankTech', it first identified the future technologies and selected five areas: DevOps, project management, APIs, cloud computing and data engineering. Last year, it expanded into three new areas: cybersecurity, data analytics and data visualisation. "We added design this year," says Srirang.

After identifying the future technologies, the bank beefed up its tech expertise. First, it decided to tap the IITs to hire engineers. "We hired close to 400 engineers in the last financial year (FY22)," says Srirang. In FY23, too, the bank roped in a similar number of engineers. It's unheard of for a bank to be inducting engineers into the risk, analytics and technology teams, but ICICI Bank has done so. It has multiple customised programmes curated under its Digital Academy to cover technology, data and design.

India's third-largest lender by assets has also aligned its strategy of engagement with external experts. The bank has an initiative where it brings in people from diverse fields every month to speak with top management. In the past two years, it has focussed heavily on people from the digital space. Recently, Rajesh Jha, part of the senior management team at Microsoft, spoke to the bank's leadership about the latest developments in the tech space.

Not just that. The bank also keeps updating its training module to be in sync with the latest technologies and processes. "I think the rate of change of the module is much higher now because our processes are changing rapidly," says Srirang. The bank is already working towards decongesting its pro-



KEY HR INITIATIVES

► It has set up a learning initiative called **Digital Academy** with partners like **IIIT Bangalore, NIIT University, Manipal UNext and Great Learning, among others**

► It encourages direct engagement of senior

management, including the MD & CEO, with branch managers

► The lender also has a roster system for senior managers working from headquarters to work in other offices within the city

► Axis Bank also has a one-stop app to attend to employees' queries

► For training new recruits, the bank conducts a quarterly review of banking content with universities

cesses internally. "We need to make sure that those changes are reflected in the curriculum," he adds.

The bank, which has 5,718 branches, also uses data science to decide which branch should be visited by the senior managers. The key deciding factors are audit score, experience of the branch manager, attrition in branch employees, etc. Bakhshi himself makes it a point to call branch managers and regional managers directly on a daily basis. "It helps in prioritising which branch needs immediate attention," says Srirang. "Communication is a very important aspect... of this whole cultural transformation," he says.

During a recent board meeting in Hyderabad, the bank invited former chairman Narayanan Va-

ghul to spend some time with the 12-member board and share his perspective.

Vaghul narrated a story of G.L. Mehta, the bank's second chairman, from 1958 to 1970. Mehta often said 'Make sure every employee's child is given the best of education so that they can go ahead and build a great career'. Vaghul said if there are two factors that will define ICICI Bank, they would be the lender's customers and its people. That's the DNA of ICICI Bank. "Customers and employees are the two fulcrums around which the leaders have to build the organisation," Vaghul had said. That's the core philosophy of the bank as well. **BT**

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